ARE SHOWING

WAGGING, BUT THE RSS-BJP KNOW THE FUTURE LIES IN ACCOMMODATION



PRAY TELL
PM Narendra Modi with RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat during the consecration ceremony in Ayodhya, Jan. 22

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

To those who weren't watching closely, it must have come as one of the more surprising after-effects of the Lok Sabha results. With the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) down from 303 to 240 seats, and the Narendra Modi government undergoing a commensurate diminution of stature, it was thought natural that the rules of discourse would alter a bit. That, if not exactly open season, it would inaugurate a phase where the ruling dispensation finds itself rendered less teflon-coated against critique. But broadsides would have been par for the course had they come from the Opposition. Instead, expressions of disapproval started emanating from the upper echelons of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), whose ties to the BJP have of late resembled that of a neglected parent.

First, none other than sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat spoke in admonitory tones. More pointed takedowns followed, including from RSS veteran Indiresh Kumar. The unusual degree of openness in their words got them wide media play—and set off much speculation. From a distance, the BJP-RSS form a compounded pair that's often read by the public as one entity. Was it really possible that there could be filial discord between the two? Could there be smoke without fire? Now that the little spree of artillery shelling has ceased and a modicum of calm has been restored, insiders warn against reading too much into that brief surge in mercury levels. The long term, they say, is organically primed for equilibrium.

To be sure, it's not as if nothing happened—blanket denials will not serve to restore a sense of uninterrupted harmony. But the words deployed reveal the nature of disaffection, and point more towards a threat of peace breaking out, not unremitting hostilities. Addressing a Sangh gathering less than a week after the election results, Bhagwat counselled restraint in behaviour and said a "true sevak never develops *ahankaar*"—or an arrogant